the wide travels of the philosopher Adi Shankaracharya, who is credited with unifying many different currents of Hindu thought.[31]

In ancient India, a couple of words were popularly used to denote outsiders. *Yona* or *Yavana* was used for foreigners from the west, derived from the Ionians or ancient Greeks.[32] Thus the large armies of Alexander of Macedon that reached the Indus in the 4th century BCE and turned back on account of homesickness would be referred to as the *yavana*s. So would Megasthenes, the Greek ambassador who visited the Mauryan capital, farther inland. The *Arthashastra*, like many texts before and after it, used the word 'mlechha' to denote the outsider, or those with foreign or even tribal origins. The word was historically used to describe outsiders from the west, and at times even those from the east.[33] It would be used to describe the Indo-Greeks, Parthians, Shakas, Kushanas and Hunas who appeared in north-west India, some of whom drove small ruling groups such as the *Gana-samgha*s of Punjab southwards or eastwards from their original inhabitations between the 2nd century BCE and 3rd century CE.[34] It would also be used to describe the invading Turko-Afghans from the north-west, made famous by the attacks of Mahmud of Ghazni in the early 11th century CE and Muhammad Ghuri in the last decade of the 12th century CE, which culminated in the formation of the Delhi Sultanate in 1206 CE.

The world 'mleccha' was also associated with a notion of impurity and, presumably sometime in the first millennium CE, with the codification of Hindu customs and laws, restrictions were placed on overseas mobility for fear of contamination on contact with the mlecchas.[35] These restrictions were placed because it was difficult to observe caste rules and rituals in distant lands, resulting in the notion of 'loss of caste upon return,' a notion that was fairly strong up to the late 19th century CE when the word *kaalapani* was in vogue to describe the forbidden dark waters.

Nevertheless maritime trade did take place in ancient India, usually separate from the Indo-Gangetic political empires and in regions less affected by caste taboos on long-distance mobility. The monsoon winds were used by sailors to cross the Arabian Sea. The west coast of India,